

Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to outline Stella College approach to the management of fees, charges, and refunds. Stella College is committed to providing clear and accurate information about fees, charges, and refund conditions to students and stakeholders. The organisation will maintain a fair and transparent process for managing payments and refunds while complying with regulatory and legal requirements.

Rationale

Ensuring transparency and fairness in financial arrangements is fundamental to fostering trust and accessibility in education and training. Clear communication of costs, payment structures, and refund processes allows students to make informed financial decisions before committing to a course. By outlining structured payment options, eligibility for funding or subsidies, and provisions for refunds, financial arrangements remain equitable and compliant with regulatory requirements. This approach not only supports consumer rights but also aligns with ethical business practices in vocational education.

A structured financial approach also enhances organisational efficiency by reducing disputes, ensuring timely payments, and maintaining compliance with legal and funding body requirements. Providing flexibility, such as instalment plans, improves accessibility for a diverse student cohort while maintaining financial sustainability. Additionally, setting clear policies for refunds and withdrawals ensures that students are treated fairly in circumstances where course participation changes, reinforcing accountability and student confidence in the organisation.

Scope

This policy applies to all prospective and enrolled students at Stella College, as well as staff involved in the administration of course fees, payments, and refunds for all programs delivered under the College's Scope of Registration.

Policy Principles

- Stella College operates with integrity and fairness in all financial dealings.
- Fee information is published and communicated clearly before enrolment.
- Refunds are processed in line with the principles of fairness, equity, and regulatory compliance.
- All financial records are accurately maintained within the student file.
- No additional or hidden charges are imposed after enrolment.

Fee Information

Each qualification or program offered by Stella College has a designated course fee, which represents the maximum amount that may be charged to a student for their chosen program. Students who do not meet payment deadlines may incur penalties, including suspension of access to learning resources and college services. A 14-day grace period will be granted to settle any outstanding payments before such penalties are applied.

Prior to the enrolment, Stella College notifies student of a range of fee information. This fee information includes:

1. All fees payable to Stella College, clearly describing all costs involved with the course,
2. How and when fees must be paid,
3. How to request a refund,
4. The conditions under which a refund would be provided.

All fees, including tuition, resource fees, and incidental costs, are also published on the Stella College website. Stella College ensures all fees and charges related to the provision of training services are outlined to all parties prior to enrolment. Information provided is clear, accurate and sufficient to enable an informed choice. The fees may vary from Course to Course. Stella College fees are designed to minimise the impact of fees and charges, through flexible payment plans, dependent on service type.

No Statement of Attainment or Qualification will be issued until full and final payment has been received.

Payment of Fees

- Fees may be paid in full or via approved instalment plans.
- Employers may pay on behalf of students under a training agreement.
- Stella College will not collect more than **\$1,500 in prepaid fees** from individual students at any time, unless fee protection arrangements (e.g., bank guarantee or tuition assurance scheme) are in place.
- Receipts are issued for all transactions, and records are securely maintained.

Refund Eligibility

Full Refunds: If student provide notice to cancel their enrolment either prior to or within 3 days of being accepted into a program, student is entitled to a full (100%) refund of fees.

Partial (Pro-Rata) Refunds: A **partial refund** may be granted where: the student withdraws after the course start date for compassionate or compelling reasons (e.g., medical condition, family emergency, or other circumstances beyond control) or student withdraws part-way through a unit or course, and training for remaining units has not been provided. Refunds are calculated based on the proportion of training services not yet delivered.

No Refund: If you provide notice to cancel your enrolment either prior to or within 3 days of being accepted into a program, you are entitled to a full (100%) refund of fees.

Refund Process

- Refund requests must be submitted in writing using the **Fee Refund Application Form**.
- Documentary evidence (e.g., medical certificate, compassionate grounds) must be attached where relevant.
- Approved refunds are processed within **14 calendar days** of the College receiving the completed application.
- Refunds are paid using the same method as the original payment unless otherwise agreed.

Special Circumstances and Fee Protection

1. Prepaid Fee: **Prepaid fee** means any fee relating to the delivery of services paid to an NVR registered training organisation by, or on behalf of an individual prior to the services to which the fee relates being delivered by the organisation.

Not more than \$1,500

Stella College does not collect more than \$1,500 in prepaid fees (fees in advance) from students at any time for any course service. As such, no further fee protection arrangements are required. The requirements that apply to prepaid fees include all fees that a student is required to pay, including enrolment fees, tuition fees, materials fees and any other fee component that is a mandatory payment for the course.

2. Provider Default: If Stella College is unable to deliver a course after commencement, affected students will be: transferred to an equivalent course at no additional cost, **or** refunded the unused portion of prepaid fees within **14 calendar days**.

3. Student Default: If a student withdraws due to illness, hardship, or visa issues, Stella College may approve a refund based on compassionate consideration.

Government-Funded Programs

Prior to enrolment, Stella College supplies each student with a Statement of Fees. The Statement of Fees provides a quote for the total cost for the course of study/enrolment, considering current circumstances (including any eligibility for concession). Stella College allows tuition fee waivers/exemptions.

Prior to enrolment, Stella College sights and retains copies of all documentation demonstrating an individual's eligibility for the tuition fee waiver/exemption granted by Stella College for audit or review purposes. Stella College allows concessions on standard fees. The concession fee is 20 per cent of Stella College's published standard tuition fee, being the fee that Stella College would have charged a non-concession government subsidised student in the same course at that time. Stella College ensures it checks an individual's eligibility for concession as part of enrolment and prior to the commencement of training.

Fee Waivers Table

Stella College grants a Fee Waiver in the circumstances below:

Circumstance:	The Training Provider must grant a Fee Waiver if:
Judy Lazarus Transition Centre	The student is from the Judy Lazarus Transition Centre (as a prisoner within the meaning of the Corrections Act 1986).
Young people on community based orders	The student is required to do training under a community-based order made under the Children, Youth and Families Act 2005 (the CYF Act).
Skills First Youth Access Initiative	The student is referred to training by the Department of Health and Human Services, the Department of Justice and Community Safety, or a referring agency.
Skills First Aboriginal Access Fee Waiver	The student self-identifies as being of Aboriginal or Torres Strait Islander descent (and is reported as such through the 'Indigenous Status Identifier' field of the Student Statistical Report) and is enrolling in a program at any level.

General Concessions

For enrolments in courses at the Certificate IV level and below, Stella College must charge the concession fee to an individual who, prior to the commencement of training, holds (or is a dependant spouse or dependent child of a holder of) a current and valid:

- *Health Care Card* issued by the Commonwealth,
- *Pensioner Concession Card*, or
- *Veteran's Gold Card*, or

Where Stella College does not charge all fees for an enrolment in one instance at the start of the program, Stella College informs students that if they obtain a Fee Concession entitlement after the commencement of training, they may present it, in which case Stella College will charge a Fee Concession for any remaining fees not yet charged.

Indigenous Completions Initiative

Under the Indigenous Completions Initiative, for enrolments in a course at any level Stella College charges the concession fee to individuals who self-identify as being of Aboriginal or Torres Strait Islander descent. Stella College retains a copy of the enrolment form on which the individual self-identified as indigenous.

Asylum Seeker VET Program

Under the Asylum Seeker VET program, for enrolments in courses at the Certificate IV level and below, Stella College charges the concession fee to an asylum seeker or trafficked person.

Appeals

Students who are dissatisfied with a refund decision may lodge an appeal under Stella College's **Complaints and Appeals Policy**. All appeals must be submitted within **14 days** of the refund decision notice.

Responsibilities

The admin manager is responsible for administering all refunds and managing fee processing to ensure accuracy and compliance with the policies. The Student Services team communicates fee policies to students and manages the submission and processing of refund applications, providing guidance and support throughout the process. The CEO / Compliance Manager oversees compliance with all relevant legislative and regulatory requirements, ensuring that refund and fee practices align with applicable laws and institutional standards.

Monitoring and Evaluation

Stella College monitors and evaluates financial management processes to ensure performance is effective and outcomes are met. A process of performance monitoring, evaluation, and reporting has been established and implemented. The organisation continually improves the effectiveness and efficiency of processes. Process performance and outcomes are regularly audited to identify and remove causes of existing and potential problems, as well as to uncover any opportunities for improvement. Please refer to the **Quality Policy** for further information on the monitoring and evaluation process.